

...and the big bug

This concerns the Windows update feature in Windows 7. Windows, by default, is set to download and install all security updates automatically without notifications (optional updates are not installed automatically). However, while the updates were being downloaded, we found out that we were unable to browse, or for that matter download e-mails to our mail client or stay online on Pidgin (Windows version). It turned out that the update feature was using up all our bandwidth. To circumvent this problem temporarily, we tried to stop the update download process. In the Windows Update control panel applet, we clicked on 'Stop Downloading', and immediately, the applet informed us that updating had been cancelled. However, we still could not browse, and the Data Traffic indicator on our router was blinking madly. We could only reach one conclusion: Windows was still downloading updates at its full capacity. We got proof of this when we resumed downloading the updates; we had paused at 85 per cent and it had resumed a full 3 per cent ahead—at 88 per cent.

The usability of the Internet from our computer during the update process was so bad that even DNS queries would not resolve. We could partially improve on this situation by switching to the OpenDNS servers, but even then pages as simple as Google's homepage were taking two to three minutes to load, and others were giving up with connection timeouts.

We believe that a combination of factors is to blame. Even though this build of Windows 7 is a release candidate, we cannot rule out a bug that makes the WU Applet say that downloading has been stopped, while in reality it is still happening. On the other hand, the fact that updates take up all of the bandwidth is a serious problem for Indian households, which typically have no more than 256 Kbps of bandwidth for unlimited usage connections. And if they have limited usage connections at higher speeds, they pay more, because Windows 7's updates are huge in size (~700 MBs has been downloaded as of now to our computer) as compared to Mandriva's ~300 MBs. But the biggest flaw we believe is that WU defaults to downloading and installing updates automatically without even notifying the user. Mandriva and most, if not all, major Linux distributions default to informing the user when updates are available, so that the users can download and install them at their own leisure, such as setting them to download overnight before going to sleep.

Judgement day

Well, Mandriva any day! Though Windows 7RC looks good, it does nothing else. And at nearly Rs 13,000 for the Ultimate Version (which has all these visual gimmicks; the lesser versions don't have Aero, don't have Media Centre and don't even look good), you're better off investing that money somewhere else. And with the kind of resource hog Windows 7 is, we'd still recommend Windows XP to any professional gamer, or to people who need some version of Windows at least. For people who can do without Windows, don't go back to Windows 7, and just switch to Linux. And now that Windows XP is off the retail shelves, you'll either have to buy Windows Server 2003, or resort to piracy to obtain Windows XP. But don't, and instead use

Musings

1. Windows does include nVidia Forceware drivers, but it doesn't include the nVidia Control Centre, making it impossible to tune the GPU by hand to deliver maximum performance. A default installation of the Mdv nVidia Forceware-GLX drivers from the repos does include the Control Centre, but it's nowhere near as advanced as the Windows version. But hey, settings are OS-specific, except overclocking.
2. The Mandriva Installer stuttered on the bootloader. It installed six entries, one for itself, one for no-framebuffer, one for failsafe, two for Windows and one for Fedora. The first Windows entry was chained to boot into sda1 and the second to sdb1. The first worked, it booted into the Windows 7 boot manager where I could choose to boot XP or 7. The second one gave an error: BOOTMGR missing. I'm certain this is a Windows problem. The Fedora menu entry didn't work as well, as GRUB faulted with a partition type unrecognised. That was rectified by changing the root entry from (hd0,2) to (hd0,1).
3. Windows 7 has a feature called subsystem for UNIX applications, somewhat like Cygwin. However, upon enabling the feature, all I found was a folder in my start menu with a URL shortcut to SUA's download site. And the download is huge.
4. Mainstream editions of Windows 7 will have a mode called Windows XP mode, which will provide a paravirtualised Windows XP on 7. This will require a CPU with virtualisation extensions.
5. To test an anti-piracy feature, we tested Microsoft Office 2007 with a known non-genuine key found on the Internet. The office-update website detected this non-genuine key and would not let us update. Cut to Windows Update, it downloaded updates for both Windows and Office, including two service packs amounting to well over 300 MB and numerous security patches.
6. On the interoperability front, it seems that MS has done some homework for a change. The stripped-down word processor in the name of Word Pad that comes bundled with the OS does support ODT files, but informs the user straight up: "Word Pad does not support all the features of this document format. Some formatting information of content might be displayed incorrectly."

Linux. And if you need a good version of Linux, use Mandriva. And for people familiar with Linux basics, Fedora is also recommended. 

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